

Session 4: Ezekiel in Historical and Literary Context

Key Takeaways

- Studying Ezekiel along the contours of its literary design helps us recover a degree of competence with the native communication conventions of the biblical authors.
- Ezekiel's vision of God while in Babylon foreshadows the later revelation of God's presence departing from the temple in Jerusalem.
- The opening movements of Ezekiel reveal that the temple and Israel have come to represent an anti-Eden. In the final movements, God gives a vision of a new Eden and a new temple.
- Prophets like Ezekiel offer us a vision of reality that transcends our typical conscious experience of the world.

Key Historical Events in the Time Period of Ezekiel

- 623: Ezekiel is born.
- 620: Josiah begins his reform of Judah (2 Kgs. 22-23).
- 612: Assyrian capital of Nineveh falls to Babylonian takeover (see Nahum, Habakkuk).
- 605: Nebuchadnezzar defeats the Egyptians at Carchemish, and Babylon takes control of Syria-Palestine.
- 598: Babylon's first attack (with Ammon and Moab) on Jerusalem, and Babylon takes the first wave of exiles (including Ezekiel; see 2 Kgs. 24:1-17).
- 595: Zedekiah initiates a rebel alliance (with Ammon, Moab, Edom, Tyre, Sidon) against Babylon (2 Kgs. 24:18-20; Jer. 27).
- 593: Ezekiel has a vision of the God-mobile (Ezek. 1:1-3).
- 588: Babylon begins the second siege of Jerusalem (2 Kgs. 25:1-2).
- 586: Jerusalem falls to Babylon, the temple is destroyed, the second wave of exiles are taken to Babylon, and Jerusalem is plundered by Edom and Ammon (2 Kgs. 25:3-2; Ezek. 33).
- 573: Ezekiel has a vision of the temple (Ezek. 40-48).
- 538: Cyrus topples the Babylonian empire and sends the Edict of Cyrus to Jewish exiles (2 Chron. 36:22-23; Ezra 1:1-4).
- 520: The first wave of exiles go from Babylon to Jerusalem (Ezra 1-6).

The Literary Design of Ezekiel

Ezekiel 1-11

Ezekiel's vision of Yahweh's presence, which is going to abandon and destroy the Jerusalem temple

A - **1:1-3:15** Ezekiel's vision of the God-mobile and his commission as a prophet
 B - **3:16-7:27** Ezekiel's basic message: warning of the coming ruin of Jerusalem and the temple
 A' - **8-11** Ezekiel's virtual tour of the defiled temple and Yahweh's exit from the city

Ezekiel 12-33

Poems, parables, and sign-acts warning of the coming destruction

- **12-14** Oracles against Israel's leaders
- **15-23** Oracles against Israel
- **24-33** Oracles against the nations

Ezekiel 34-48

Promises of vindication and restoration for Israel, culminating in a vision of the heavenly temple

A - **34-37** Promises of hope for covenant renewal and Israel's restoration
 B - **38-39** Yahweh's final victory over evil among the nations
 A' - **40-48** Yahweh's presence returns to his people, resulting in a new creation

Ezekiel 1-48 Vertical. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Dated Superscriptions in Ezekiel

Reference	Text Date	Month/Year
1:3	30th year (?) / 4th month / 5th day (= 5th year after Jehoiakin's exile)	7/593 God-mobile vision #1
3:16	5th year / 4th month / 12th day	7/593 God-mobile vision #2
8:1	6th year / 6th month / 5th day	9/592 Old temple vision
20:1	7th year / 5th month / 10th day	8/591
24:1	9th year / 10th month / 10th day	1/588
26:1	11th year / X month / 1st day	?/586
29:1	10th year / 10th month / 12th day	1/587

Dated Superscriptions in Ezekiel. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Reference	Text Date	Month/Year
29:17	27th year / 1st month / 1st day	4/571
30:20	11th year / 1st month / 7th day	4/587
31:1	11th year / 3rd month / 1st day	6/587
32:1	12th year / 12th month / 1st day	3/585
32:17	12th year / X month / 15th day	?/585
33:21	12th year / 10th month / 5th day	1/585
40:1	25th year / X month / 10th day	4?/573 New temple vision
<i>Dated Superscriptions in Ezekiel. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).</i>		

Reflection Question

Summarize the major points of the three main sections of Ezekiel (chapters 1-11, 12-33, and 34-48).